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# SFL genre-based writing research in the university EAP classroom: A systematic review from 1995 to 2024

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ABSTRACT

The Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) genre-based approach (GBA), or the 'Sydney school genre pedagogy' (Green & Lee, 1994), is a theoretically grounded, justice-oriented approach to literacy that aims to make disciplinary ways of knowing, being and doing more explicit and visible to students (Martin & Rose, 2008). This paper presents an in-depth synthesis of research investigating SFL GBA in undergraduate and postgraduate EAP writing published in the 30-year period from 1995 to 2024, with a focus on how this pedagogy has been utilised and recontextualised in different EAP writing contexts to support learners to meet their diverse contextual needs. In total, 70 studies situated in tertiary education across 20 countries met the inclusion criteria and were analysed for their methodological design, disciplinary context and genre focus. This in-depth review identifies specific reasons researchers have studied GBA in EAP contexts, as well as key takeaways and areas for further investigation. The review offers readers insight into the diverse needs, challenges and adaptations addressed and explored in this body of research and aims to inspire and inform other researcher-practitioners working in higher education to integrate the SFL GBA into their EAP writing curriculum and to investigate the impact of such an approach on their students' developing writing proficiency.

## 1. Introduction and rationale

English for Academic Purposes (EAP) programmes, offered globally in higher education institutions, aim to equip learners, predominantly L2 users, with the specialised language practices required for disciplinary study and professional communication (Hyland & Hamp-Lyons, 2002). Transitioning from secondary-level general English instruction to the register-specific demands of academic discourse poses persistent challenges, particularly in contexts where English functions primarily as an academic lingua franca rather than a societal medium (Aizawa, 2023). EAP writing pedagogy, accordingly, varies widely, with individual instructors or departments selecting frameworks and materials suited to local curricula, learner profiles, and institutional priorities. For practitioners newly

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tasked with EAP course design, identifying evidence-based, transferable approaches from among the available EAP literature remains a formidable undertaking.

Among the pedagogies adopted worldwide, the Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) genre-based approach (GBA)—often termed the 'Sydney School' approach (Martin & Rose, 2008)—has gained particular prominence. Grounded in Hallidayan linguistics, SFL GBA is a theoretically coherent, socially oriented framework that renders explicit the social purposes, staged structures, and lexicogrammatical realisations of target genres (Rose & Martin, 2012). From an SFL perspective, genre is understood as "a staged, goal-oriented, and purposeful social activity that people engage in as members of their culture" (Martin, 1984, p. 25). It operates within the broader context of culture, while *register* refers to the situational context of a text, realised through three variables: tenor (the interactions and relationships enacted between participants), field (what is happening), and mode (the organisation of communication). These register variables are construed through the three metafunctions of language: ideational (representations of experience), interpersonal (interactions, negotiating roles and attitudes), and textual (organising information into coherent text; Halliday, 1978).

Investigating these register variables and their realisation through the metafunctions enables a systematic understanding of how genres are achieved and function within specific social contexts (Yasuda, 2017). This perspective not only illuminates the dynamic interaction of meaning-making resources across the three metafunctions, but also makes visible the choices available to learners at different strata of the language system. By foregrounding these relationships, SFL provides a powerful framework for analysing discourse and designing pedagogic tasks that link linguistic form to communicative purpose. This explicit focus on language, combined with the tools for analysing writing development in school genres, makes SFL GBA distinct: it foregrounds linguistic theory and research-informed principles for teaching and learning, providing educators with pedagogical models that contextualise writing instruction (Kartika-Ningsih, 2015). Originally developed as a literacy intervention for disadvantaged Australian primary students (Rothery, 1994), SFL GBA has since been recontextualised across educational levels, languages, and geopolitical settings, retaining its commitment to democratising access to powerful disciplinary discourses (Martin & Rose, 2008).

Central to SFL GBA is the Teaching and Learning Cycle (TLC), a scaffolded instructional sequence comprising Building the Field, Joint Deconstruction, Joint Construction, and Independent Construction (Feez, 1999; Rothery, 1994). This cycle systematically guides learners from building contextual knowledge to producing autonomous texts. In various contexts, the TLC has been purposefully adapted: the Expanded Teaching and Learning Cycle (ETLC) incorporates needs analysis and reflective assessment (Gebhard, 2019); the Onion Model visually layers macro-genres, elemental genres, and language strata (Humphrey & Economou, 2015); and the 4x4 Toolkit maps four knowledge strata (genre, register, discourse semantics, lexicogrammar) across Halliday's three metafunctions, providing diagnostic precision for multilayered text analysis (Humphrey & Robinson, 2012). Complementary SFL-based innovations such as the Reading to Learn program further extend the TLC by systematising scaffolding through detailed reading preparation and tightly sequenced learning cycles that integrate reading and writing (Rose & Martin, 2012). Collectively, these tools enable educators to foreground the dynamic interplay of context, purpose, and language, cultivating transferable genre awareness among diverse L2 writers.

The application of SFL GBA to English for Academic Purposes (EAP) writing emerged in the mid-1990s, catalysed by Australian curriculum initiatives like *Write it Right* (Iedema et al., 1994). This approach was subsequently adapted in contexts such as Hong Kong, Singapore, Qatar, Chile, the UK, and mainland China (Christie & Derewianka, 2008). Early scholarship prioritised descriptive genre analysis and curriculum design, documenting enhanced textual coherence and register sensitivity (Hyon, 1996). The 2000s marked a shift toward empirical intervention studies, which employed quasi-experimental and case-study designs to demonstrate student gains in genre-specific moves, thematic progression, and the use of appraisal resources (Emilia, 2005; Schleppegrell, 2002). In the following years, research expanded to include multimodal genres (James, 2021), corpus approaches (Gómez-Laich, Miller & Pessoa, 2019), disciplinary specificity (Mitchell & Pessoa, 2017), and technology-mediated implementations, thereby mirroring the evolving ecology of academic communication.

Despite this cumulative trajectory, no synthesis has systematically inventoried SFL GBA interventions in tertiary EAP writing across its full temporal arc. Critically, no study has mapped publication trajectories, methodological maturation, geographical dispersion, or outcome heterogeneity from 1995 to 2024. Such lacunae impede evidence-informed curriculum scaling, teacher professional development offerings, and cross-contextual benchmarking.

This systematic synthesis addresses this gap by examining 70 peer-reviewed publications on the SFL genre-based approach in EAP writing, retrieved from ProQuest, ERIC, and LLBA. Guided by PRISMA protocols (Page et al., 2021), we pursue three research questions:

1. How has the SFL genre-based approach been recontextualised and studied in different EAP writing contexts?
2. How has SFL genre-pedagogy been employed and adapted to address diverse goals in English for Academic Purposes in higher education?
3. What can be learnt from existing research drawing on GBA in EAP higher education?

## 2. Methods

To explore these research questions, we examined a subset of studies identified as part of a larger investigation into SFL GBA across levels of schooling. To compile that corpus of studies, two two-member review teams independently worked through the following stages before coming together to compare results and finalise the study corpus. The first stage involved a search and compilation of potential studies for inclusion. We conducted broad searches of three databases, ProQuest, LLBA and ERIC, using "genre-based

approach", "Systemic Functional Linguistics", "SFL", and "genre pedagogy" as the search terms. The criteria for this initial search were guided by year of publication (1995-2024), language of publication (English), and publication type. Specifically, we restricted our search to journal articles, edited book chapters and doctoral dissertations. Conference proceedings and reports were excluded as we were not able to independently verify the review processes involved in their development. Books were also excluded, as monographs in applied linguistics typically offer conceptual or pedagogical exposition rather than reporting primary empirical data, and systematic review guidance emphasises aligning inclusion criteria to the aim of synthesising empirical studies (Kaymakcioglu & Thomas, 2024; Macaro, 2019). Notably, while many reviews also exclude doctoral theses on the grounds that they are not peer reviewed in the same way as other publications, we concur with Macaro's (2019) view that doctoral examinations are often at least as rigorous than peer review, if not more, warranting their inclusion in the review. Consequently, the final corpus comprised journal articles, edited book chapters and doctoral theses.

The ProQuest database search yielded 7306 results, of which the titles and abstracts from the first 1850 studies, representing 25% of the total search returns, were carefully reviewed. This limit was set due to diminishing returns; for example, when reviewing the titles and abstracts for entries 1300-1500, only 50 additional unique studies were identified. Beyond this point, most of the search results were repeats of studies we had already identified for further analysis. Subsequent searches in the LLBA database yielded 1861 results and the ERIC database yielded 1810 results. The titles and abstracts of these studies were carefully reviewed and in total, 724 studies from the ProQuest search and 456 studies from the LLBA and ERIC databases were identified for potential inclusion. Given the substantial yield from these initial searches, further keyword searches were deemed unnecessary.

During the second stage of the review, more stringent inclusion and exclusion criteria were applied to the examination of the 1180 studies identified during the initial search stage. For example, studies were examined in more depth to confirm that the SFL genre-based approach had been employed. Several studies mentioned SFL GBA as part of their literature review but ultimately drew upon other genre approaches, such as Rhetorical Genre Studies (Miller, 1984) or English for Specific Purposes (Swales, 1990; n = 640). We also chose to focus exclusively on empirical studies involving data collection and analysis, excluding any teaching reflections, conceptual or theoretical papers that had not collected and analysed data as part of their investigation. During this stage, any study that did not investigate second (L2) or foreign language (FL) writing instruction was further excluded from the analysis.

Once a study clearly met the inclusion criteria, key bibliographic data (e.g., authors, title, year, type of publication, journal/book name, doi, etc.) and information about the study context and research design was recorded on a master excel spreadsheet (e.g., geographic location, language focus, discipline, level of schooling, study design, length of study, number of participants, etc.). We then collated and compared the studies that the two review teams had compiled and the full five-member review team discussed any inconsistencies. The studies included in the master spreadsheet were then individually re-examined by at least one member of the team with further information about the studies recorded for the analysis (e.g., genre focus, pedagogical framework, etc.). During this review, some studies were flagged for reconsideration; the full team met to review and discuss these studies against the inclusion criteria, which led to more exclusions.

For the larger investigation, 190 studies met the inclusion criteria and were included in the final analysis. The present paper reports on a subset of those studies situated in undergraduate and postgraduate classrooms that examined SFL GBA in the teaching of English for Academic Purposes (EAP). This focus reflects the aim of the present study, which is to understand how SFL-informed genre pedagogy is taken up in university contexts where the teaching of academic English is a central goal.

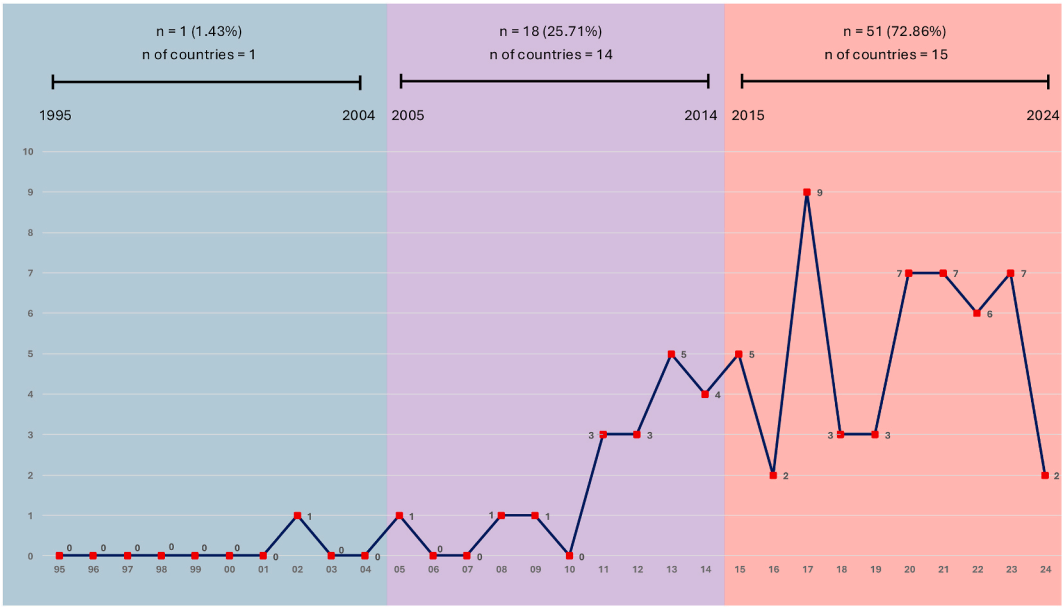



**Fig. 1.** SFL genre EAP research (1995-2024).

## 3. Findings

### 3.1. Overview of publication trends

In total, our investigation identified 70 EAP-focused genre studies situated within university education over the thirty-year period. Of those, two-thirds were published as journal articles (n = 46; 65.7%), a further 24.3% were doctoral dissertations (n = 17), and 10% were published as edited book chapters (n = 7). Notably, 94.3% of these studies (n = 66) were published within the past 15 years (2010-2024), with nearly three-quarters (72.9%) concentrated in the most recent decade (n = 51; 2015-2024). As illustrated in Fig. 1, prior to 2013, the highest number of genre-based EAP investigations situated in the tertiary education context in any given year was three. From 2013 onwards, there was an increase in the number of GBA EAP-focused investigations, with the highest number recorded in 2017 (n = 9).

We were further interested in the regional contexts where these studies took place. As illustrated in Table 1, the 70 investigations were conducted in 20 different countries, with the largest proportion of studies situated in Asia (n = 23; 32.86%), followed by the Middle East (n = 14; 20%), North America (n = 14; 20%), and the Pacific Islands (n = 10; 14.29%). Only five of the studies took place in Europe (7.14%), three in South America (4.29%), and one in Africa (1.43%). The countries which recorded the highest number of SFL genre-based investigations in the university EAP classroom were the USA (n = 13), Qatar (n = 12), Japan (n = 8), China (n = 7), and Indonesia (n = 6).

Notably, over the thirty-year period examined, the adoption of SFL GBA for EAP instruction grew not only in scale, but also in its geographic reach. In the first fifteen years (1995-2009), only four studies were published, confined to the United States (n = 2), Brunei (n = 1), and Indonesia (n = 1). Between 2010 and 2015, research activity accelerated, with studies continuing in the USA (n = 1) and Indonesia (n = 1) and expanding to twelve additional countries, including Spain (n = 3), Japan (n = 3), Hong Kong (n = 2), the United Kingdom (n = 2), and one study each in Australia, China, Israel, Singapore, South Africa, Taiwan, Thailand, and Vietnam. This trend intensified in the most recent decade (2015-2024), when SFL GBA was implemented in 15 countries for the teaching of EAP. During this ten-year period, the Middle East emerged as a key hub for SFL GBA, with Qatar contributing 12 studies, making it the second most represented country across the entire period.

This concentration of research in Qatar demonstrates a systematic effort to address the challenges of academic writing in an English-medium instruction (EMI) context through language-focused pedagogy. Across these studies, Silvia Pessoa and her collaborators employed SFL GBA pedagogy to scaffold a range of genres, initially focusing on argumentative writing in history (Miller et al., 2016; Mitchell & Pessoa, 2017; Pessoa et al., 2017; Pessoa et al., 2018) and design courses (Gómez-Laich, Miller & Pessoa, 2019), and later expanding to case analyses in business and information systems programs (e.g., Gómez-Laich et al., 2021; Pessoa et al., 2022). Collectively, the body of work published by the Qatar collaborative stands as a model of sustained collaboration between linguistic and disciplinary experts, demonstrating how integrating expertise can transform EAP instruction in EMI universities.

The only other country to record more than ten studies over the three decades of this investigation was the United States. However, in contrast to the concentrated and collaborative body of work in Qatar, SFL GBA research in the USA has been more dispersed, involving a range of scholars across diverse institutions and pedagogical contexts. A few of the investigations examine genre uptake in specialised contexts such as law (Kessler, 2020; Xu, 2020) and science (Schleppegrell, 2002), whereas others used SFL GBA in more general EAP contexts to address challenges in integrating and situating evidence (Mori, 2017; Zhao & Li, 2023), develop students' metalinguistic awareness (Sembiante et al., 2021) and scaffold bilingual and multilingual learners' engagement with valued academic genres (e.g., Ramirez, 2017; Spence-Davis, 2020).

### 3.2. Research design and pedagogical frameworks

The genre literature was further explored in terms of its research design and genre foci. The majority of the studies (n = 57; 81.43%) involved an instructional intervention, and many of these (n = 33) drew upon the Teaching Learning Cycle. While the TLC provides a

**Table 1**
SFL Genre EAP research by geographical location (1995-2024).

| Region | Country | Total (n) | Total (%) | Region | Country | Total (n) | Total (%) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Asia | | 23 | 32.86% | Pacific Islands | | 10 | 14.29% |
| | Japan | 8 | | | Indonesia | 6 | |
| | China | 7 | | | Australia | 2 | |
| | Hong Kong | 2 | | | Brunei | 1 | |
| | Taiwan | 2 | | | Singapore | 1 | |
| | Thailand | 2 | | Europe | | 5 | 7.14% |
| | Vietnam | 2 | | | Spain | 3 | |
| North America | | 14 | 20% | | United Kingdom | 2 | |
| | United States | 13 | | South America | | 3 | 4.29% |
| | Canada | 1 | | | Colombia | 2 | |
| Middle East | | 14 | 20% | | Chile | 1 | |
| | Qatar | 12 | | Africa | | 1 | 1.43% |
| | Israel | 1 | | | South Africa | 1 | |
| | Oman | 1 | | # of countries | | 20 | |

common framework for scaffolding genre instruction, several studies adapted it to their local context to meet the students' linguistic needs and genre demands. For example, in the Indonesian context, Emilia (2005) combined the TLC with critical literacy to address the demands of the government curriculum requirements and in Colombia, Durán-Bautista (2021) embedded systematic peer feedback into the joint construction phase to promote learner independence. Some interventions adhered more strictly to the three-stage TLC to teach core academic genres such as expositions, summaries and discussions (e.g., Chen & Su, 2012; Nagao, 2019), whereas others focused more specifically on a single stage of the cycle. For example, Caplan (2017), Dreyfus et al. (2011), and Dreyfus and Macnaught (2013) analysed the role of joint construction, emphasising its critical importance for fostering collaborative meaning-making and genre uptake. Other investigations adapted the TLC to include complementary frameworks, such as the Onion Model (e.g., Gómez-Laich et al., 2021; Pessoa, Gómez-Laich & Mitchell, 2020), Reading to Learn (e.g., Li et al., 2024; Mamac & Bangga, 2023), and task-based language teaching (TBLT; e.g., Yasuda, 2012, 2017).

Those studies which involved an intervention tended to be designed as case studies or action research projects, with the efficacy of the program assessed through analyses of students' proficiency, as evidenced through their pre- and post-intervention writing samples. For example, to examine the effects of the GBA on 20 Vietnamese EFL learners' argument genre writing, Trinh and Truc (2014) assessed the students' writing before, at the mid-point and after the GBA intervention and found significant improvements in the students' writing performance (see also, Pham & Minh, 2023). Other studies examined students' improved writing proficiency alongside their growing genre awareness. For example, Kessler (2020) found that EAL learners enrolled in a Master of Laws program with an integrated genre-based approach demonstrated improvement in both their writing proficiency and their metacognitive genre awareness (see also, Nagao, 2019; Sembiante et al., 2021).

Although most of the GBA literature explored the efficacy and impact of an intervention, thirteen of the studies used SFL GBA as an analytical lens rather than as a pedagogical framework for classroom implementation. Some employed SFL genre theory to diagnose challenges in student writing and map genre expectations, such as EMI students' emergent arguments in history (Pessoa et al., 2017) and ESL students' difficulties when writing laboratory reports (Schleppegrell, 2002). Others used genre analyses to inform curriculum mapping and pedagogical design in disciplinary contexts, such as Humphrey and Hao's (2013) work in biology reports and Rodriguez-Arancón's (2013) mapping of business genres. Such investigations demonstrate the versatility of SFL GBA as an analytical tool for identifying the linguistic, rhetorical and developmental patterns of academic writing, even when it is not deployed to scaffold instruction.

The 70 EAP studies were further analysed for their instructional context and genre focus. In total, 45 studies described their instructional context as a general EAP classroom (e.g., 'college composition', James, 2021; IELTS Academic, Morgan, 2023; or 'Intensive English Program', Caplan, 2017); the remaining 25 studies were situated within a disciplinary context such as Business (Portman, 2014; Rodríguez-Arancón, 2013), Science (Changpueng, 2013; Klos, 2011), History (Miller et al., 2016; Pessoa et al., 2017), Law (Kessler, 2020; Xu, 2020), Applied Linguistics (Dreyfus & Macnaught, 2013; Zhao & Li, 2023), and Organisational Behaviour (Mitchell, Pessoa, Gómez-Laich, & Maune, 2021; Pessoa et al., 2022). Such investigations examined disciplinary genres such as case analyses (Gómez-Laich et al., 2023; Mitchell, Pessoa, & Gómez-Laich, 2021), emails (Yasuda, 2011, 2012), lab reports (Humphrey & Hao, 2013; Schleppegrell, 2002), literature reviews and research writing (Afifi, 2020; Hussein, 2015). For those studies situated in more general EAP classrooms, the most common genre foci were argumentative texts such as expositions and discussions (e.g., Emilia & Hamied, 2015; Liu, 2024; Mamac & Bangga, 2023; Nagao, 2022), descriptions (e.g., Caplan, 2017) and summary or reflection genres (e.g., Brooke, 2015; Chen & Su, 2012). Some of these more general EAP studies focused on specific aspects of academic registers, such as source integration (Spence-Davis, 2020), lexical density (Johnson, 2008) nominalisation (Liu, 2024), lexical phrases (e.g., Cai, 2014; Cai, 2016) and writer identity (e.g., Smirnova, 2020).

### *3.3. Applications and affordances of SFL GBA to address EAP learners' writing needs*

To understand why the researchers selected SFL GBA as their targeted approach, it helps to investigate what they described as the specific needs of the learners and/or instructors in the classrooms they studied. One of the largest needs EAP instructors worked to address was the transition from the procedures and expectations of secondary school or other English courses to the demands of university English for Academic Purposes. Researchers described patterns in secondary education such as a focus on prescriptive grammar (e.g., Rahayu & Musyarofah, 2022) and/or teacher-dominated instruction (e.g., Nagao, 2019). Yasuda (2011), for example, explained how writing exercises in L2 classrooms were "often simply a medium for grammar practice or vocabulary exercises" (p. 112) rather than about the composition of longer, cohesive texts. As such, university EAP instructors saw helping students adjust to new expectations for language learning, and particularly the expectations of university writing, as a major goal.

Another common need identified by instructors related to specific target genres in EAP courses and students' awareness of related discourse- and language-level features. Some researchers ascribed these issues to not understanding what distinguishes one genre from another or falling back on the genres most commonly prompted in school. For example, Pessoa et al. (2019) observed that students had "difficulty shifting from reporting to analysing" when writing case analyses (p. 43). The goals in these studies related to improving student writing specifically for those targeted genres, rather than general expectations for academic writing.

Writing in particular disciplines also presented challenges, such as taking an EAP course in a science or business program. These contexts included student writing issues such as shifting from learning language as the target content to learning disciplinary content in one's second language (e.g., Ramírez, 2017; Schleppegrell, 2002). Another challenge, identified in multiple studies carried out by English department members in Qatar, was that disciplinary faculty often had expertise in their subject area, but had limited or no training in linguistics or writing pedagogy (e.g., Mitchell, Pessoa, Gómez-Laich, & Maune, 2021; Pessoa et al., 2019).

Some research in the dataset directly linked their aims or student needs with the applicability of SFL GBA, such as the ability to

unpack a specific genre's structure and/or language features using SFL analytic tools, whereas other studies more generally made an argument for GBA as an approach with explicit metalanguage for discussing language use across levels of text. Yasuda (2017), for example, argued that SFL supports teachers and learners in understanding "the kind of choices that exist at various strata of the language system in genres, tasks, and contexts" (p. 579). Researchers often offered evidence from existing literature on the affordances of SFL or GBA for writing instruction. One of the most common arguments for using GBA was the idea of being able to explicitly discuss the metafunctions of language (ideational, interpersonal, and textual) or unpack the contextual factors that impact a text by discussing register variables related to field, tenor, and mode.

Others argued for SFL GBA in EAP classrooms because of specific analyses that allow "both a framework for teaching content and a means for analysing student output" (Morgan, 2023, p. 169). Mori (2017), for example, argued for the applicability of the Appraisal framework and SFL more generally, stating that both have "a variety of classification systems and inter-related levels of analyses that range in complexity. It is possible to incorporate just a few or all of the taxonomies" (p. 7). Another reason GBA was identified as the preferred approach was because prior work had been conducted in the same discipline as the given EAP course, such as history (e.g., Miller et al., 2016) or science (e.g., Humphrey & Hao, 2013), or because of established pedagogical models that scaffold the teaching of genre-based instruction (e.g., Reading to Learn, used by Ramírez, 2017; Li et al., 2024; Mamac & Bangga, 2023; or the Onion Model, used by Gómez-Laich et al., 2021; Mitchell, Pessoa, & Gómez-Laich, 2021).

In summary, the EAP courses in this review, while located in different national contexts or focused on different disciplines, identified some common needs for students working on improving academic writing skills. Some needs related to the general shift from secondary school English courses to university writing demands, while others were tied to challenges that writing in specific genres or disciplines pose. Across this range of student needs, the researchers argued for the strengths of using an SFL-informed genre-based approach, as it "combines the formal and functional properties of a language while providing insights into the specific social context and purpose" (Pham & Minh, 2023, p. 191). Overall, the alignment between EAP and GBA seemed to result from SFL's explicit ways of discussing language choice, tools for analysing the output, and established pedagogical frameworks for structuring GBA instruction.

### 3.4. Impact of SFL GBA on student writing and genre awareness

Various takeaways can be drawn from the collective findings of the GBA research in EAP contexts. As discussed earlier, over half of the studies evaluated the quality of student writing in some manner, often through the use of pre- and post-tests. Of those studies, most argued that students' writing proficiency improved based on their assessment criteria (e.g., Emilia, 2005; Fu & Liu, 2025; Gómez Burgos, 2017; Martínez Lirola, 2015; Pham & Minh, 2023). For example, Pessoa et al. (2022) offered evidence from students' grades, feedback surveys, and a "close linguistic analysis" to demonstrate the effectiveness of the intervention (p. 244). Other studies reported more mixed results, with improvement in some specific aspects of student writing and no improvement in others. Yasuda (2012) for example, found students' overall score improved based on a holistic measure, but there was little change in grammatical complexity or lexical density.

Some studies' findings offered a description rather than evaluation of students' use of various language features after a GBA intervention. Other common categories of key findings were students' awareness of genre and/or register, such as awareness of audience, or students' perceptions of writing, either of their own skills or generally how they perceive text after encountering the GBA. Emilia and Hamied (2015), for example, combined their results related to student writing with a questionnaire where they asked students to share their opinions on the teaching program and its effect on their writing.

Researchers also explored differences in student writing, with some focusing on differences between experiment and control groups (e.g., Caplan, 2017; Fu & Liu, 2025), some on differences by proficiency level (e.g., Nagao, 2022), and some looking at the differences of individual student writers (e.g., Gómez-Laich et al., 2021). In studies which reported on differences between the experiment and control groups, a common refrain was the improvements in the experiment group regarding their use of expected genre features, compared to limited development in the control groups. By proficiency level, studies reported varied patterns depending on their research focus. In a study of Japanese university students, for example, Nagao (2022) explored differences by SFL metafunction and found lower proficiency students improved in their use of ideational and interpersonal resources, while higher proficiency students showed more improvement in textual features, such as structure and coherence.

### 3.5. Contributions to pedagogy and limitations of SFL GBA

While much of the GBA research in EAP contexts focused on students, many of the studies also reported findings related to teaching practices, either describing how the teachers enacted a genre-based unit or evaluating the effect of instructional practices. For example, Dreyfus et al. (2011) and Dreyfus and Macnaught (2013) described how joint construction (as part of the TLC) was used in university EAP contexts. Another common focus of the EAP literature was on mapping the linguistic features and/or structure of a particular genre or text type used in that particular context (e.g. literature reviews, Afifi, 2020; laboratory reports, Humphrey & Hao, 2013; or legal essays, Xu, 2020).

Based on these key findings, the authors of the research included in this review reported various contributions they see their work offering to the field. Due to the number of articles that found improvement in the quality of student writing, a contribution commonly named was the effect or effectiveness of the intervention. Many of the researchers positioned their work as providing further support for previous GBA research, offered specific pedagogical suggestions for using GBA in EAP contexts, or demonstrated how GBA was adapted for a particular teaching context. Cai (2014), for example, offered an example of using GBA in China with MA students, while Kessler (2020) examined teaching writing with GBA in law classes in the United States. Other findings identified challenges in

implementing GBA or challenges for student writers (e.g., Chen & Su, 2012; Correa & Echeverri, 2017; Mitchell & Pessoa, 2017). Many researchers also used their findings to argue for the GBA approach, and its adaptability, generally or for a specific related teaching practice, such as using mentor texts (e.g., Brooke, 2015; Changpueng, 2013; Hussein, 2015).

Another commonly cited contribution was the value of combining GBA and another instructional approach or activity, such as a task-based approach (Yasuda, 2012) or integrating peer feedback (Durán-Bautista, 2021). A group working in Qatar (discussed earlier, e.g. Pessoa et al., 2019 or Gomez-Laich et al., 2021) stated that their research contributes models of interdisciplinary collaboration within a university. In that context, the English department works closely with instructors in other departments, such as history or information systems, to support students' English proficiency in those disciplines. Finally, the studies that were aimed at understanding a particular genre stated that they contributed the mapping of that genre's features or structure to the field.

The publications included in this review also outlined the limitations of their studies. The most frequently named limitation related to issues of generalisability, typically based on the specific characteristics of the context, the limited number of genres explored, or a small sample size. Another common limitation was the length of time, either of the study or of the intervention, and the need for more longitudinal research or evidence of transfer. Approximately one-ninth of the articles stated that not having a control or comparison group was a limitation. There were also a number of other study-specific limitations mentioned, such as limitations based on the choice of analysis or instrument, constraints from the particular course or context, and potential effects from other factors, for example, task difficulty, resources available outside the classroom, or technology.

## 4. Discussion and conclusions

The research reviewed in this paper provides an overview of SFL GBA's utility in English for Academic Purpose courses in higher education. The literature demonstrates how GBA has been adapted and contextualized across 20 national contexts and in both general EAP and discipline-specific classrooms. As instructors have identified a variety of target genres or tasks for their students, they have worked to incorporate GBA in their individual courses. Viewed collectively, these studies indicate that GBA is not only adaptable, but consistently perceived as an effective means of supporting students' control of academic writing.

By integrating quantitative bibliometric mapping with qualitative thematic synthesis, this paper delivers an inaugural panorama of SFL GBA in EAP writing, equipping educators, curriculum designers, and policymakers with a robust evidence base to optimise pedagogy in an era of intensified global academic mobility. This synthesis moves beyond isolated case studies, offering a consolidated view of how GBA has been employed to meet diverse academic writing needs, across diverse populations. On balance, the field's collective findings point to GBA's value as a principled and transparent approach that helps EAP learners recognise and successfully deploy the linguistic resources valued in academic communities.

Moving forward, research that addresses the gaps, limitations, and future directions identified in this body of research offers areas for growth in the GBA EAP field. Researchers can develop more projects with control groups to explore what is similar or different in the effect of a GBA-focused course compared to other EAP approaches. Longitudinal data, larger-scale studies, and cross-context comparisons would further strengthen the evidence base. Enlisting colleagues to assess interrater reliability would also strengthen the validity of findings, especially alongside the teacher-scored rubrics that dominate current assessments of effectiveness. Applying standardised measures of writing quality across different contexts, perhaps in tandem with course-specific rubrics, could also offer new insights into the effectiveness of GBA. Such advances would enable the field to more convincingly demonstrate the efficacy of SFL GBA, as well as illuminate the pedagogical conditions and classroom practices that maximise its impact.

The publications included in this review mostly result from individual instances of implementing GBA in an EAP context. Bringing them together in such a manner steers the work away from isolated examples and toward a broader view of GBA's utility. For EAP educators wondering how to begin, the research in this review offers models and suggestions across contexts and genres. The ways scholars have adapted GBA for their particular EAP courses demonstrate the flexibility of the approach, while the number of studies showing improvement in student writing offer strong support for using a genre-based approach to teach academic writing. The overview of research provided here offers further evidence for GBA as an explicit, established, accessible and adaptable model for unpacking the expectations and language features of the various academic genres students are asked to produce in university settings. By synthesising connections across the research in the field, this review aims to deepen our collective understanding of GBA trends and demonstrate for EAP instructors how genre-based pedagogy can empower students across the globe to make valued meanings in their academic and professional contexts. Taken together, these insights consolidate our understanding of how SFL genre-based pedagogy is currently being enacted in EAP settings and highlight its ongoing potential to shape effective, equitable academic writing instruction in higher education.

## CRediT authorship contribution statement

**Cassi Liardet:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Anne-Coleman Webre:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis. **Akiko Nagao:** Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Harni Kartika-Ningsih:** Writing – review & editing, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Winfred Wenhui Xuan:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

## Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process

During the preparation of this work the authors used Microsoft Copilot to support aspects of the revision process, including suggesting alternative wording, strengthening transitions, and improving clarity in response to reviewer comments. After using this tool/service, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

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